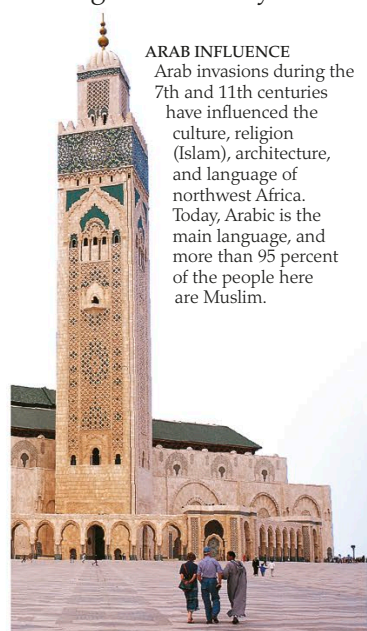




# Northwest Africa

FOUR COUNTRIES, plus the disputed area of Western Sahara, make up this part of Africa. Algeria, Libya, and Tunisia have rich supplies of oil and natural gas that boost their economies. Morocco relies on tourism, phosphates used for chemicals and fertilizer, and agriculture. In the fertile valleys of the Atlas Mountains, farmers grow grapes, citrus fruit, dates, and olives. The area also attracts tourists to its colorful markets, historical sites, and sandy beaches. The Sahara Desert dominates the region, particularly in Algeria and Libya.



**ARAB INFLUENCE**  
Arab invasions during the 7th and 11th centuries have influenced the culture, religion (Islam), architecture, and language of northwest Africa. Today, Arabic is the main language, and more than 95 percent of the people here are Muslim.

Muslims going to worship at the Hassan II mosque in Casablanca, Morocco



**MOROCCAN MARKET**  
In a souk, or market, craftworkers sell handmade products to tourists. Goods are displayed in booths along the bustling streets.

**BERBERS**  
The Berber people were the original inhabitants of northwest Africa. Most now live in the Atlas Mountains or the desert. Although most Berbers converted to Islam when the Arabs arrived, they kept their own language and way of life. In 2001, Algeria recognized Berber (Tamazight) as an official language.

Berber woman working on the land in the Atlas Mountains



**SUN AND SEA**  
Many tourists visit Tunisia and Morocco each year to enjoy the warm climate and sandy beaches. Tourism provides jobs for the local people and brings much-needed income.

